

Everything You Treasure—For a World Free from Nuclear Weapons

The exhibition “Everything You Treasure—For a World Free From Nuclear Weapons” was jointly created by SGI (Soka Gakkai International) and the International Campaign to Abolish Nuclear Weapons (ICAN). Launched in Hiroshima in August 2012 at the 20th World Congress of the International Physicians for the Prevention of Nuclear War (IPPNW), the exhibition commemorates the 55th anniversary of second Soka Gakkai president Josei Toda’s September 8, 1957, Declaration Calling for the Abolition of Nuclear Weapons.

The exhibition has been shown at various international conferences such as the Second Preparatory Committee (PrepCom) for the 2015 Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) Review Conference held in Geneva in April 2013, the first Conference on the Humanitarian Impact of Nuclear Weapons held in Oslo, Norway, in March 2013 and the second in Nayarit, Mexico, in February 2014.

Objectives

- *To build a broader nuclear abolition constituency by providing the opportunity to learn about nuclear weapons from multiple viewpoints and in line with diverse interests*
- *To provide information and perspectives that empower people to take action for “the future we want”*
- *To generate popular momentum toward the outlawing of nuclear weapons through a treaty prohibiting nuclear weapons*

Concept

Nuclear weapons are a continuing and direct threat to all that we, collectively and individually, treasure. They impact us in ways ranging from humanitarian, environmental and economic to medical, generational and spiritual. We ourselves are the solution to the abolition of nuclear weapons which provides an opportunity to transform society, win over violence and establish a culture of peace.

Contents

The exhibition has a total of 40 panels (20 pairs) divided into 3 sections and is available in English, Spanish, Japanese and Russian.

Section 1: What Do We Treasure?

Examines the historical realities of nuclear weapons use and their existence as a continuing threat to human security and sustainability—a safe and secure life for all. Viewers are invited to reflect on what is most important to them and the need to protect this from nuclear weapons.

Section 2: Learning More

Examines the nuclear weapons issue from 12 perspectives: Humanitarian, Environmental, Medical, Economic, Human Rights, Energy, Scientific, Political, Spiritual, Gender, Generational and Security.

Section 3: Changing Our Worldview

Presents an overview of disarmament achievements. Highlighting, that we ourselves are the solution, viewers are invited to share their personal commitment for action toward a nuclear-weapon-free world and the realization of an international treaty to prohibit nuclear weapons.

SCRIPT FOR CURATORS

PANEL 1

“Welcome to *Everything You Treasure—For a World Free from Nuclear Weapons*.

This exhibition is designed to be more than a collection of panels. It is a space for dialogue—a place where we can learn together, exchange views, and share our ideas and experiences as we think about how to create a better world.

As you go through the exhibition, we invite you to carry your ‘passport to the future.’ You can use it to reflect on the things you treasure, the thoughts and feelings that the exhibition inspires in you, and the actions you can take for the future.

So, as we begin, we invite you to think about one question: **What do you treasure?”**

PANEL 2

“Our exhibition begins with a fundamental question: How do we protect the things we treasure?

The desire to protect the people and things we love is a natural human impulse. Throughout history, this desire has inspired us to build homes, make clothing, and grow food.

However, the desire to protect what we value from other people has also led to the development of increasingly destructive weapons, eventually culminating in the development and use of nuclear weapons in 1945.

Today, we are becoming increasingly aware that our world is deeply interconnected. Our choices and actions affect not only those around us but also people and the planet far into the future.

This panel reminds us that we cannot truly protect the things we treasure alone, in isolation, or through conflict. When we benefit others, we also benefit ourselves; when we harm others, we ultimately harm ourselves.

Every action has an effect—sometimes in ways, places, and even times that we cannot imagine.”

PANEL 3

“This panel reminds us that no one is immune from global threats. Humanity faces many challenges, including armed conflict, poverty and hunger, human rights violations, natural disasters, economic crises, environmental degradation, climate change, and the threat of global pandemics.

Of all these threats, however, nuclear weapons pose the most acute and catastrophic danger—and yet, they are also the most preventable.

According to the information presented on this panel, SIPRI reported approximately 13,400 nuclear warheads worldwide as of 2020. Any use of these weapons would have catastrophic humanitarian consequences, instantly killing vast numbers of people, destroying population centers, and potentially disrupting the global climate.

The panel also presents what is called the ‘Pyramid of Violence.’ Nuclear weapons stand at the very top, followed by regional armed conflicts, low-level conflict, and societal violence. As the pyramid spreads downward, it reaches into our daily lives—through conflict and mistrust, crime, domestic violence and abuse, and even the hurtful words we sometimes direct at one another.

This reminds us that the culture of violence is interconnected. If we hope to eliminate the most destructive forms of violence, we must also work to overcome violence in its many forms in our everyday lives.”

PANEL 4

“This panel shows us the devastating reality of what nuclear weapons can do. In August 1945, atomic bombs were dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. By the end of that year, approximately 140,000 people had died in Hiroshima and an estimated 70,000 in Nagasaki.

Tsutomu Yamaguchi, the only officially recognized survivor of both bombings, said: ‘The reason that I hate the atomic bomb is because of what it does to the dignity of human beings.’

But the threat of nuclear weapons is not something that belongs only to the past. As the chart on this panel shows, nuclear weapons continue to exist in the world today. The danger of their spread to more states—and potentially to terrorist organizations—remains real. There is also the possibility that nuclear weapons could be used by accident or deliberately.

The message of this panel is a powerful one: everything we treasure could be reduced to ash in a moment. That is why the threat of nuclear weapons continues to concern all of humanity.”

PANEL 5 The Humanitarian Challenge

“This panel reminds us of a fundamental principle of war and international humanitarian law: cities are not targets, and there must be a distinction between soldiers and civilians.

However, nuclear weapons challenge this principle in the most extreme way. Their massive destructive force makes it impossible to contain their effects or distinguish between military targets and civilian populations. Their long-term consequences would also undermine the social and ecological foundations of future generations.

The humanitarian impact of modern warfare is also reflected in the increasing number of civilian casualties. During World War I, only about 5 percent of casualties were civilians. Today, in internal conflicts, civilians account for 75 percent or more.

International law has increasingly recognized the catastrophic humanitarian consequences of nuclear weapons. In 1996, the International Court of Justice stated that the use or threat of use of nuclear weapons would generally be contrary to the principles of international law. In 2017, the United Nations adopted the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons, which prohibits activities such as developing, possessing, stockpiling, using, and threatening to use nuclear weapons.

The International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement has also called for concrete action toward preventing the use and achieving the elimination of nuclear weapons. The message of this panel is clear: the protection of civilians and the protection of our shared future require us to confront the threat posed by nuclear weapons.”

PANEL 6 The Environmental Challenge

“This panel highlights the environmental challenge posed by nuclear weapons. Climate scientist Alan Robock warns that nuclear weapons are among the greatest environmental dangers created by humanity.

Experts estimate that even a limited regional nuclear war involving just 100 Hiroshima-sized nuclear weapons—less than 0.1% of the explosive yield of the world's nuclear arsenal—could cause tens of millions of immediate deaths and unprecedented global climate disruption.

The smoke and dust from burning cities could block sunlight, causing sudden global cooling and disrupting rainfall and agriculture. This could lead to what scientists call nuclear famine, with as many as one billion people dying from starvation.

The environmental damage does not begin only when nuclear weapons are used. Their production, from uranium mining through testing, has polluted soil and water around the world. The Hanford Nuclear Reservation in the United States, once part of the atomic bomb project during World War II, is now described in this exhibition as the most contaminated site in North America.

The message of this panel is clear: even a so-called ‘limited’ nuclear war would have consequences far beyond the countries involved, affecting the climate, food supply, environment, and future of people around the world.”

PANEL 7 The Medical Challenge

“This panel presents the medical challenge posed by nuclear weapons. Unlike ordinary weapons, a nuclear explosion causes multiple forms of injury at the same time: blast damage, severe burns and thermal injuries, and exposure to dangerous levels of radiation.

Ionizing radiation can severely damage living cells and the bone marrow. It can cause radiation sickness, weaken the body's ability to fight infection, damage DNA, and lead to mutations and cancer that may appear years later.

Survivors such as Sueko Takada experienced these long-term effects. After surviving the atomic bombing of Nagasaki, she was later diagnosed with malignant lymphomas and continued to suffer from recurring tumors.

The blast itself can instantly kill people near ground zero and cause severe injuries far beyond it. The intense heat can cause severe burns, blindness, and massive fires that may develop into firestorms.

The World Health Organization stated in 1983 that nuclear weapons constitute the greatest immediate threat to the health and survival of humankind.

Physicians and scientists who have studied and treated victims of nuclear explosions have therefore emphasized that there is no adequate medical response to a nuclear war.

This is why organizations such as the International Physicians for the Prevention of Nuclear War advocate the elimination of nuclear weapons. Their message is that prevention is the only possible ‘cure’ for nuclear war.”

PANEL 8 The Economic Challenge

“This panel focuses on the economic challenge of nuclear weapons. Maintaining and modernizing nuclear arsenals requires enormous financial resources. According to the information presented here, in 2011 the world's nuclear-armed states collectively spent more than 100 billion US dollars on their nuclear programs.

This raises an important question about opportunity cost. Opportunity cost means the value of what we give up when we choose to spend our resources on something else. What could be achieved if even a portion of the money spent on nuclear weapons were redirected toward more socially useful purposes?

The panel also highlights the role of the financial sector. According to ICAN's 2018 ‘Don't Bank on the Bomb’ report, 329 banks, pension funds, insurance companies, and asset managers in 24 countries had substantial investments in companies involved in nuclear weapons production.

Organizations and campaigners around the world are therefore calling on financial institutions to stop investing in the nuclear arms industry and are encouraging governments to redirect military spending toward human development, decent work, poverty reduction, and action on climate change.

The central question of this panel is: Are we using our resources to build weapons, or to build a better future?”

PANEL 9 The Human Rights Challenge

“This panel explores nuclear weapons as a human rights issue. At the heart of human rights is the right to life and bodily security. The existence of weapons capable of killing millions—or even billions—of people challenges the very value of human life and dignity.

The panel also raises concerns about secrecy and democratic control. Decisions about nuclear weapons can be made under extreme time pressure. A long-range ballistic missile may reach its target in as little as 15 to 30 minutes, leaving political leaders only minutes to decide whether to launch a retaliatory strike. Such a decision may be made without meaningful participation from the public or even elected representatives.

The human rights impact is also evident in the history of nuclear testing. Nuclear tests have often been conducted on the lands of indigenous and minority communities, far from those making the decisions. These communities have suffered displacement, disruption of their traditional way of life, and serious long-term health effects.

This panel reminds us that nuclear disarmament is not only a security issue. It is also a humanitarian and human rights endeavor—one concerned with protecting human dignity, the right to life, and the survival of future generations.”

PANEL 10 The Energy Challenge

“This panel explores what is known as the Energy Challenge. Nuclear energy is often presented as a civilian technology, but it is closely connected to the dangers of nuclear weapons, radioactive waste, and the risk of proliferation.

Nuclear reactors generate energy through controlled fission. However, if that process can no longer be properly controlled, a nuclear meltdown can occur, as seen in Three Mile Island, Chernobyl, and Fukushima, potentially releasing large quantities of radioactive pollution into the environment.

Nuclear power also creates highly radioactive waste that must remain isolated from living organisms for extremely long periods. This raises an extraordinary question: how do we warn people, tens of thousands of years into the future, to stay away from these dangerous materials?

The panel also highlights Onkalo in Finland, a deep underground facility designed to store nuclear waste. The challenge is not simply storing the waste, but ensuring that it remains safely isolated for at least 100,000 years.

Another concern is proliferation. Nuclear reactors can produce materials such as plutonium, which can potentially be used in nuclear weapons. This is why international efforts to secure nuclear materials and prevent their diversion are so important.

Finally, the panel invites us to consider alternative and sustainable sources of energy, such as wind, solar, geothermal, hydro, and tidal energy—sources that do not leave a legacy of long-lasting radioactive waste.”

PANEL 11 The Scientific Challenge

“This panel explores the Scientific Challenge. Scientific discoveries in the 20th century transformed our understanding of energy and matter, but they also made possible the creation of nuclear weapons. The Manhattan Project represents a turning point, bringing together scientific research and military objectives to develop the atomic bomb.

The development and use of these weapons also led many scientists to reflect on their responsibility to humanity. The 1955 Russell-Einstein Manifesto called on people to ‘remember your humanity,’ and the Pugwash Conferences brought scientists and public figures together to reduce the danger of armed conflict and seek peaceful solutions to global security threats.

This panel also reminds us that science is not only part of the history of nuclear weapons—it is also essential to eliminating the nuclear threat. Scientists and technical experts are needed to verify disarmament, safeguard nuclear materials, and ensure nuclear safety and security.

One example is the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty and its International Monitoring System. Using a worldwide network of scientific technologies—including seismic, hydroacoustic, infrasound, and radionuclide monitoring—experts can help detect nuclear explosions anywhere on Earth. The central challenge, therefore, is not to reject science, but to ensure that scientific knowledge and technology are guided by responsibility and used for the protection of humanity.”

PANEL 12 The Political Challenge

“This panel explores the Political Challenge. Traditionally, security has been understood in terms of protecting the sovereignty and borders of individual states. But nuclear weapons changed the meaning of security because the consequences of nuclear war cannot be contained within national borders. During the Cold War, both the Eastern and Western blocs developed massive nuclear arsenals. This led to the doctrine known as Mutual Assured Destruction, or MAD, in which both sides possessed the capacity to destroy one another. Humanity was forced to live under the fragile assumption that these weapons would never be used.

The Cuban Missile Crisis of 1962 showed just how dangerous this situation was, bringing the United States and the Soviet Union to the brink of nuclear war. It became clear that nuclear weapons threatened not only the countries involved, but all of humanity.

As a result, political cooperation increasingly became recognized as necessary for survival. Over the decades, countries have created bilateral and multilateral agreements to reduce nuclear dangers, control nuclear weapons, and advance disarmament.

This timeline shows some of those important political efforts—from the early international agreements on nuclear energy and testing, to the Non-Proliferation Treaty, arms reduction agreements, and ultimately the 2017 Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons.

The central message of this panel is that no country can achieve true security in isolation. In a world with nuclear weapons, security must be built through cooperation, dialogue, and collective efforts toward disarmament.”

PANEL 13 The Spiritual Challenge

“This panel presents the Spiritual Challenge. Nuclear weapons are not only a political or military issue—they are also a profound challenge to our values and our understanding of human life.

The existence of nuclear weapons forces humanity to live under the shadow of catastrophic destruction. They raise a fundamental moral question: Can any political or military objective ever justify the mass killing of innocent human beings and the destruction of the world we share?

Representatives of different religious, ethical, and spiritual traditions have spoken out against nuclear weapons. Despite their differences, they share important values—the dignity of every human person, the peaceful settlement of disputes, protection of the environment, and responsibility for future generations.

One of the powerful ideas presented in this panel is that eliminating nuclear weapons is not enough by itself. As spiritual leader Mātā Amṛtānandamayī Devī said, we must also eliminate the ‘nuclear weapons of the mind’—the fear, hatred, and ways of thinking that make us willing to destroy or dehumanize others.

This panel reminds us that the challenge of nuclear abolition ultimately begins with a recognition of our shared humanity. We all bear a common responsibility to protect one another, our planet, and the future from the threat of nuclear destruction.”

PANEL 14 The Gender Challenge

“Panel 14 explores the gender challenge of nuclear weapons. It shows how nuclear weapons are connected to questions of power, vulnerability and the human consequences of war, which are often overlooked in traditional military and security discussions. The panel also highlights the devastating experiences of women affected by nuclear testing, including reproductive cancers and birth defects described by Lijon Eknilang of Rongelap. At the same

time, it recognizes the powerful role women have played in the global movement for peace and nuclear disarmament—from the women of Greenham Common to organizations such as the Women’s International League for Peace and Freedom. This panel reminds us that women are not only victims of nuclear violence; they have also been at the forefront of creating a more peaceful and humane world.”

PANEL 15 The Generational Challenge

“Panel 15 presents the generational challenge of nuclear abolition. As the survivors of Hiroshima and Nagasaki grow older, an important question confronts us: Who will carry their message into the future? For decades, the hibakusha have shared their experiences in the hope that no one, anywhere, will ever suffer as they did.

The panel also reveals a challenge among young people. Many students believe that nuclear weapons may be used in the future, yet far fewer believe that their complete elimination is possible. This makes peace and disarmament education more important than ever.

Through initiatives such as Hibakusha Stories, the IPPNW Nuclear Weapons Inheritance Project, Amplify, and the training of future nonproliferation specialists, younger generations are being empowered to carry forward the work of nuclear disarmament. Panel 15 reminds us that the future is not something we simply inherit—it is something we must take responsibility for and create. The question for every generation is: what kind of world will we leave to those who come after us?”

PANEL 16 The Security Challenge

“Panel 16 asks us to rethink what we mean by security. Traditionally, nuclear weapons have been seen as the ultimate guarantee of national security.

During the Cold War, the logic of deterrence assumed that no rational state would launch a nuclear attack because it would face devastating retaliation. But this thinking has serious limitations. The risk of accidental nuclear war, the possibility of states taking irrational or suicidal risks, and the danger of terrorist groups obtaining nuclear materials or weapons all challenge the idea that deterrence can guarantee our safety. For groups that have nothing to protect and nothing to lose, the threat of retaliation may mean nothing.

The panel therefore introduces the concept of human security. Real security is not simply the protection of borders or military strength. It is a world in which people are free from poverty, hunger, preventable disease, human rights abuses, and violence.

The question before us is simple: Which world is truly safer—a world of heavily armed states living in fear, or a world where people’s basic needs are met and their dignity is protected?”

PANEL 17

“Panel 17 shows us that a world free from nuclear weapons is not merely an ideal—it is something nations have already begun to achieve. Nuclear-Weapon-Free Zones now cover more than half of the Earth’s surface, demonstrating that countries can choose cooperation and collective security over nuclear deterrence.

Several countries have also voluntarily abandoned nuclear weapons or nuclear weapons programs. South Africa dismantled its nuclear arsenal, while countries such as Brazil and Argentina ended their weapons development programs.

The panel also reminds us of the success of international campaigns to ban landmines and cluster munitions. These examples show that determined governments, international organizations, and civil society can work together to prohibit weapons once considered necessary.

The message is clear: nuclear disarmament is possible. The challenge is to expand these successes and build the political will needed to create a truly nuclear-weapons-free world.”

PANEL 18

“Panel 18 brings us to a historic turning point in the global movement for nuclear disarmament. On January 22, 2021, the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons—or TPNW—entered into force, officially establishing a new international legal and moral norm: nuclear weapons must never be used under any circumstances.

The treaty is especially significant because it recognizes the suffering and testimony of the hibakusha and other victims of nuclear weapons. Their experiences transformed the issue from an abstract question of military strategy into a deeply human and humanitarian concern.

The TPNW prohibits the development, production, possession, use, and threat of use of nuclear weapons. Its ultimate goal, however, is not simply prohibition, but the complete and permanent elimination of these weapons.

This treaty was made possible not only by governments, but also by civil society, survivors, activists, and ordinary citizens around the world. It demonstrates that international law and public opinion can change when people refuse to accept the unacceptable.

And this brings the exhibition’s message directly to each of us: the first step is to know and to share. Talk about nuclear weapons and the ban treaty with the people you treasure. Each conversation can help build a stronger public demand for peace and move us closer to a world free from nuclear weapons.

The future we imagine begins with the actions we take today.”

PANEL 19

“Panel 19 brings us to a deeper question: **What does it really mean to reach zero?**

A world without nuclear weapons should not simply mean removing one terrible weapon while leaving behind the same patterns of violence, fear, injustice, and mistrust. The struggle for nuclear abolition is also an opportunity to transform our relationships—with one another, with our societies, and with the world itself.

As Rebecca Johnson reminds us, nuclear disarmament is both a destination and a journey. Reaching zero is the goal, but the process of getting there requires us to develop the values that make lasting peace possible.

The panel emphasizes that this transformation begins with individual choices. Qualities such as honesty, dialogue, respect, sharing, caring, and self-control may seem simple, but they are the foundation of a more peaceful world.

To abolish nuclear weapons is to demonstrate self-mastery as a human species. It means proving that we are not powerless before the destructive technologies we have created—that we have the wisdom and courage to choose life over destruction.

And perhaps the greatest lesson is this: if humanity can come together to eliminate the nuclear threat, we can also work together to address other global challenges. A world of zero nuclear weapons can become a new foundation—a base camp—for the greater journey of building a world where every person can live in dignity, security, and peace.”

PANEL 20

“We have now reached the final panel of the exhibition. Panel 20 brings together one of its most important messages: **we are all connected.**

When we recognize our interdependence, we understand that we cannot build our own happiness or security on the fear and suffering of others. In the nuclear age, no nation can achieve lasting security alone. Real security can only be created through cooperation—when governments and civil society, realists and dreamers, work together toward a common future.

But this message also begins with each one of us. We all have people, dreams, and values that we treasure. The question is: **What is the future you want?**

How would you describe it? And what action will you take to help create it?

As Eleanor Roosevelt said, *‘We are going to learn to live together, and if we are to live together, we have to talk.’* Dialogue, mutual understanding, and collaboration are not optional—they are essential to our shared survival.

And this is where **the power of one person** becomes important. A great human revolution in the life of one individual can contribute to a change in the destiny of all humankind. Each of us can begin by choosing respect over hatred, dialogue over conflict, and hope over resignation.

So as we conclude this exhibition, I invite you to think about the people and things you treasure most.

What kind of world do you want to protect and pass on to future generations?

Please take a moment to write your thoughts, hopes, or personal pledge on the **Peace Wall**. Your voice is part of a much larger movement to create a world free from nuclear weapons and a culture of lasting peace.

Thank you very much for joining us, and let us continue working together for the future we want and deserve.”